



Mumbai. Here beauticians offer a wellness cocktail—massage, manicure, pedicure, perm to artificial hair-pieces for chemotherapy patients.

"Corporate customers are serious about well-being and they are driving the wellness boom," says Dr Ranjan Pai, managing director of Manipal Education and Medical Group in Bangalore. No wonder, the Manipal group has set up Manipal Cure and Care, which offers a mix of wellness products and services—health

wellness retail space," affirms Prateek Jain, senior industry analyst with Frost & Sullivan. "From Religare Wellness by Fortis, Apollo Pharmacy, Reliance Wellness, Manipal Cure & Care, Medica Shoppe, Medplus Health Services to Guardian Life care."

In the grand scheme of things, how we perceive wellness zeroes down to physical attractiveness. As a 2008 Synovate survey reports, 40 per cent Indians would change their looks if they could, 30 per cent think beauty products make a person more attractive, and if money was not an issue one in five would have plastic surgery. No wonder, the beauty-fitness-nutrition industry is growing at a blistering clip. "The new age consumer is aware, confident, demanding and likes to try out new concepts," sums up Vandana Luthra, who founded VLCC Healthcare Ltd, India's largest health and wellness chain. She would know. The one-stop wellness destination has spread to 225 locations across 90 cities in India, UAE, Oman, Bahrain and Nepal today. "Wellness is no longer seen as an indulgence of the rich. People now want best of services and maximum return for the money spent," she says. To please her demanding and discerning customers, Luthra has taken to innovations: from chain of beauty shops, health focused restaurants, institutes in India and abroad. VLCC's portfolio touches upon five out of the seven wellness categories—nutrition, rejuvenation, fitness/ slimming, beauty and counselling.

"Spa is emerging as the three-letter magic word," says Marya. "And it sums up the new craving for physical, mental, social and spiritual well-being." The "spa experience" encompasses an entire range of settings (resorts, hotels, health cruises, clubs and day spas) and treatments (from simple skin cleansing to weight loss to curing complex disorders). At 25-35 per cent a year, spas are on a significant growth path, says the FICCI-Ernst & Young report. There are over 2,300 spas in the country. The best-known is, of course, Soukya in Bangalore. This tranquil oasis—dotted with Nallukettu style cottages, water-bodies and greenery—run by Dr Issac Mathai shot to fame when the who's who of the world started dropping by. To make wellness ever more relevant, Mathai has started, Sahaya, a 50-bed integrated

HEMANT CHAWLA/www.indiatodayimages.com

Corporate Wellness Initiatives

■ Non-compensation expenses as a % of employee expenses
□ Non-compensation expenses as a % of revenue

Financial Services
■ 0.18%
□ 1.78%

Leisure and Hospitality
■ 11.41%
□ 1.82%

ITES/BPO
■ 11.38%
□ 4.41%

IT
■ 6.41%
□ 0.42%

42%

of corporates do not offer any wellness facilities and 37% of employees do not have the time to work out.

packages to skin care products, premium exercise machines, anti-snoring devices to cosmeceuticals. Such one-stop wellness destinations—offering retail pharmacy, clinics and diagnostic facilities along with health goods and foods, supplements, ayurvedic, beauty and hygiene products—mark an emerging trend. "Most hospital chains and pharmacies are entering into

Source: Assocham survey "Corporate Workforce: Chronic and Lifestyle Disease", 2009